

Reasonable Accommodations Policy

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Applicable to Azim Premji University, Bengaluru

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1. Introduction

Azim Premji University is committed to fostering an inclusive environment where every student, regardless of their abilities, is supported to thrive. Guided by the vision of contributing to a just, equitable, humane, and sustainable society, the University integrates this commitment into its pedagogy, campus life, and community engagement. Within this framework, we aim to provide reasonable accommodations that enable full participation, while ensuring that the core learning outcomes and academic integrity of our programmes remain uncompromised. This policy outlines the purpose, scope, and applicability of reasonable accommodations to support students with disabilities in all aspects of academic life at Azim Premji University.

2. Guiding Principles

The University's approach to disability inclusion is rooted in the principles of dignity, respect, equity, and non-discrimination. We recognise that each individual's needs and experiences are unique, and accommodations are designed to support meaningful participation without altering the essential requirements of the academic programmes. Our practices are guided by a commitment to collaboration, and a proactive effort to remove barriers, whether physical, attitudinal, or systemic, that may hinder full inclusion.

2.1 Inclusion and Equity

At Azim Premji University, inclusion and equity are fundamental values that guide our commitment to creating a supportive and accessible environment for all students. We recognize the diverse needs of our community and strive to remove barriers that may hinder participation or learning.

2.2 Respect for Privacy and Dignity

The University is committed to upholding the privacy and dignity of every student, especially those requesting reasonable accommodations. All information related to a student's disability and accommodation needs is handled with confidentiality and shared only with relevant personnel on a need-to-know basis. This approach enables students to feel safe, respected, and valued within the campus community, fostering an environment of trust and inclusion.

2.3 Non-Discrimination

Azim Premji University upholds a policy of non-discrimination, ensuring that students with disabilities are treated fairly and equitably in all aspects of university life.

3. Definitions

3.1 Person with Disability

According to the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016, "Person with Disability" means a person with long-term physical, mental, intellectual, or sensory impairment which, in interaction with barriers, hinders their full and effective participation in society equally with others.

The Act identifies the following 21 specific disabilities:

1. Acid Attack Victims
2. Blindness
3. Hearing Impairment
4. Leprosy
5. Locomotor Disability
6. Low Vision
7. Mental Illness
8. Autism Spectrum Disorder
9. Cerebral Palsy
10. Chronic Neurological Conditions
11. Dwarfism
12. Haemophilia
13. Intellectual Disability
14. Multiple Sclerosis
15. Muscular Dystrophy
16. Multiple Disabilities
17. Parkinson's Disease
18. Sickle Cell Disease
19. Specific Learning Disabilities
20. Speech and Language Disability

21. Thalassemia

3.2 Reasonable Accommodation

As per RPwD Act, 2016, the term “reasonable accommodation” means necessary and appropriate modification and adjustments, without imposing a disproportionate or undue burden, to ensure persons with disabilities the enjoyment or exercise of rights equally with others.

4. Legal and Institutional Framework

4.1 Relevant Legislation

4.1.1 RPwD Act, 2016, mandates that educational institutions provide reasonable accommodations, ensure accessibility, and eliminate barriers to learning and participation. Azim Premji University aligns its practices with this legal framework to uphold the dignity and rights of students with disabilities and to foster an inclusive and supportive academic environment.

4.1.2 The Mental Healthcare Act, 2017 was passed to provide mental healthcare and services for persons with mental illness and to protect, promote and fulfil the rights of such persons during delivery of mental healthcare and services and for related matters.

4.2 Institutional Policies and Commitments

Azim Premji University is guided by its core values of equity, inclusion, and social justice. The University’s policies reflect a strong commitment to creating an accessible and enabling environment for all students, including those with disabilities. This includes ensuring fair opportunities, reasonable accommodations, and barrier-free access across academic, residential, and co-curricular spaces. While the University strives to offer meaningful support through reasonable accommodations and inclusive practices, the policy excludes situations that fall beyond the scope of what can be addressed within an academic setting.

5. Types of Reasonable Accommodations

5.1 Reasonable Accommodations During Admissions Process

Reasonable accommodations may be provided to support equal opportunity during entrance tests, interviews, or other stages of the selection process. These may include additional time during the entrance test (additional 20 minutes per hour), accessible test formats (zoom feature), assistive technology (use of calculator), the presence of a scribe or interpreter or wheelchair access if needed. Applicants are encouraged to inform the University of any specific requirements at the time of filling up the application form, so that necessary arrangements can be made in a respectful and timely manner.

5.2 Reasonable Accommodations After Admission - Academic Support

Reasonable accommodations are tailored to meet individual needs, enabling all students to access and succeed in their educational pursuits. While all students must meet the same academic requirements for earning a degree, the University provides reasonable accommodations individualised for the needs of each student with disability.

Nature of support	Examples
Assessment Support	Extended time, quiet environment, staggered submission deadlines
In-Classroom Support	Note-taker (classmate), Sharing material prior to class, preferential seating and Assistive listening devices
Out-of Classroom Teaching Learning Support	Readers, peer tutors and buddies
Accessible Content	Screen reader compatible content, tactile diagram of images, image descriptions, audio files, etc.
Assistive Technology Support	Assistive technology lending support, assistive technology training based on disability type
Fieldwork Support	Support in orientation, field buddy, curation of organization or location

5.3 Reasonable Accommodations for Campus Life

We provide reasonable accommodations which include catering to physical, infrastructural, digital, residential, cultural, extra-curricular and other needs. These ensure equal and full participation for students in campus life.

Nature of support	Examples
Classroom Infrastructure Support	Classrooms accessibility, washroom accessibility, assistive listening devices
Mobility Support	Wheelchair-accessible ramps, elevators, restrooms, and hostel rooms, tactile pathways (In progress)
Daily Living and Recreation Support	Peer buddy support, Room allocations as per requirement if possible, (e.g., closer to washrooms), Hybrid options e.g., go home every weekend for therapy sessions, Inclusive access to sports and cultural activities, wherever possible

5.4 Other Support

The University's Frameworks of Standards for Qualifications allows Individualised Education Plans, when required, including extended timeline for completion of the academic programme.

6. Request Process

6.1 Who can Request

Reasonable accommodations are availed by diverse groups of students. The service delivery and the process flow for each group to avail reasonable accommodations may be different. Currently, the University provides reasonable accommodations for the following four categories of students:

1. Students with Disabilities (As recognised by RPwD Act, 2016) and Neurodiversity, as determined by a competent medical professional
2. Students in Mental Health Crisis (those that are both recognised within the RPwD Act and those not recognised as having disabilities), determined by a competent medical professional
3. Students with significant medical needs (chronic and severe acute) which impact their academic work, determined by a competent medical professional
4. Students in Family Crisis

6.2 How to Submit a Request

A student seeking reasonable accommodations has to apply by filling in a form within 15 days of the start of every semester. There is a review and approval process (described below) after which a letter of detailing Reasonable Accommodations approved for the student is issued to the student.

The student has the responsibility to self-identify themselves and request reasonable accommodations within the timelines and provide the requested documentation. The student has to also meet the academic standards expected of all students. Provision of reasonable accommodations does not relax the requirement of meeting the academic standards of their respective programmes.

6.3 Required Documentation

Students requesting reasonable accommodations must submit a valid UDID (Unique Disability ID) card or a recent report from a qualified medical / mental health practitioner on the disability or need for support. These documents help the Office of Disability Inclusion accurately assess the student's needs and arrange suitable support.

7. Review and Decision-Making Process

7.1 Review Process

Students must apply for reasonable accommodations by submitting the prescribed form within 15 days of the start of the semester. Requests are reviewed by the Office of Disability Inclusion as per the review categories Review 1 and Review 2. Review 1 are those which are straightforward such as additional time for tests or use of screen reader. Review 2 are requests which are complex, involving multiple diagnoses/conditions and multiple stakeholders for decision making. Reasonable accommodations during field practice will be decided in consultation with respective schools and field sites. Any accommodation beyond on-campus support will be subject to appropriate approvals. Once the review is complete, final decisions are communicated through the Reasonable Accommodation Letter.

Requests for new/ additional reasonable accommodations during the semester due to new diagnoses or mid-semester emergencies, may be considered on a case-by-case basis, with revisions permitted only in exceptional circumstances.

7.2 Timelines for Review

While the exact timeline may vary depending on the complexity of the request and the availability of documentation, the Office of Disability Inclusion aims to complete the review process within 2 to 3 weeks of receiving all required information, on average. Certain cases may require longer for review.

7.3 Communication of Decision

Once a request for reasonable accommodation has been reviewed, the Office of Disability Inclusion will communicate the decision to the student in a clear and timely manner through Reasonable Accommodation Letter. The communication will outline the approved accommodations, their scope, and any conditions or timelines associated with their implementation

7.4 Appeal Process

A student may appeal against the reasonable accommodations provided by the Office of Disability Inclusion. Prior to appealing, the student must have provided the required documentation to the Office of Disability Inclusion for consideration.

The appeal must be made to the Registrar through the Registrar's Office. The Registrar will review the appeal and take action. If required, the Registrar may consult relevant bodies in the University.

8. Roles and Responsibilities

8.1 Role of the Individual Requesting Accommodation

The individual seeking accommodation plays an active role in the process by initiating the request and providing relevant documentation to support their needs. They are encouraged to communicate openly and in a timely manner with the Office of Disability Inclusion to enable appropriate planning and support. It is also important for the student to engage in follow-up discussions, participate in the review process, and inform the University of any changes in their condition or requirements to ensure continued and effective support.

8.2 Role of faculty and other University members

Faculty and other University members play a key role in fostering an inclusive learning environment by supporting the implementation of reasonable accommodations in their respective areas. They are expected to collaborate with the Office of Disability Inclusion, respect the confidentiality of the student, and make necessary adjustments without compromising academic standards. All members of the University are expected to maintain open and empathetic communication with students to enable an effective learning environment.

8.3 Role of the Office of Disability Inclusion

The Office of Disability Inclusion serves as the central coordinating body for facilitating reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities and other who may require support. It is responsible for reviewing requests, verifying documentation, consulting with relevant stakeholders, and ensuring appropriate accommodations are provided in a timely and confidential manner. The Office of Disability Inclusion also plays a key role in promoting awareness about disability inclusion, supporting faculty and staff in implementing accommodations, and regularly reviewing the effectiveness of the provisions made.

8.4 Role of Peer Support Group / Volunteers

Volunteer support forms the core of sustainable, inclusive services at the Office of Disability Inclusion, while also building awareness and empathy across the student community. Volunteers assist students with disabilities in roles such as readers, writers, prompters, lab assistants, note takers, and peer tutors or mentors. These roles span academic, co-curricular, and residential life, offering both academic and non-academic support to ensure full participation in campus life.

8.5 Involvement of Stakeholders in the implementation of reasonable accommodations

Category Of Accommodation	Type Of Accommodation	Stakeholders Involved
Academic Support	Assessment Support	Teaching Faculty, Faculty Mentors, Programme Coordinators, Programme Office, Office of Disability Inclusion

	In Classroom Support	Teaching Faculty, Faculty Mentors, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Out of Classroom Support	Teaching Faculty, Faculty Mentors, Academic Resource Centre, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Field Work support	Teaching Faculty, Faculty Mentors, Programme Office, Programme Coordinators, Field Practice Coordinators, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Accessible Content	Teaching Faculty, Faculty Mentors, Academic Resource Centre, Library Team, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Assistive Technology Support (Lending and Training)	Library Team, Office of Disability Inclusion, Facilities
Campus Life Support	Classroom Infrastructure Support	Teaching Faculty, Faculty Mentors, Programme Office, Infrastructure Management Function, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Hostel Room Allocation	Faculty Mentors, Infrastructure Management Function, Resident Mentor Team, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Mobility	Faculty Mentors, Infrastructure Management Function, Office of Disability Inclusion
	Daily Living and Recreation	Faculty Mentors, Resident Mentor Team Student Affairs, Office of Disability Inclusion
Other Support	Student Specific Needs	Faculty Mentors/Student Advisors, Programme Coordinators, Resident Mentors, Office of Disability Inclusion

9. Monitoring and Compliance

9.1 Periodic Review of Accommodations

Reasonable accommodations provided to students will be reviewed periodically to ensure they remain relevant and effective in supporting the student's academic progress.

9.2 Addressing Non-Compliance and Grievances

Instances of non-compliance with this policy will be addressed with sensitivity. The Office of Disability Inclusion will engage with relevant individuals to understand the concern, offer appropriate guidance, and collaboratively take corrective steps.

9.3 Confidentiality and Data Protection

Disability or diagnosis disclosures, approved reasonable accommodations, and associated processes are handled with confidentiality. Such information may be shared on a need-to-know basis with university members (faculty, Programme Coordinators, School Directors, and others) in order to transact classes, administer suitable assessments, adjust field practice components, etc. All members are expected to treat this information as

confidential, maintain confidentiality and use the information strictly for implementing the reasonable accommodations. All disability documentation and related paperwork will be maintained by the Office of Disability Inclusion, in coordination with relevant functions at the University.

10. Policy Review and Updates

The Reasonable Accommodation Policy will undergo a formal review periodically, if required by changes in legislation, institutional priorities, or feedback from stakeholders.

Any amendments will be communicated clearly to the University community, and updated versions will be made available in accessible formats to all stakeholders.